

Lesson 20: Rhetorical strategies

HS192 Introduction to Writing - 2
@ IITGN, 2025-26



Today's learning objective

**Analyze persuasive writing and
identify rhetorical techniques**

Persuasion

Persuasive writing is any writing that intends to convince an audience of the author's position on a topic. Opinions articles in newspapers are good examples of it.

The art of persuasion is called **rhethoric**.

In order to understand someone else's argument, we must engage in a process called **rhethorical analysis**.

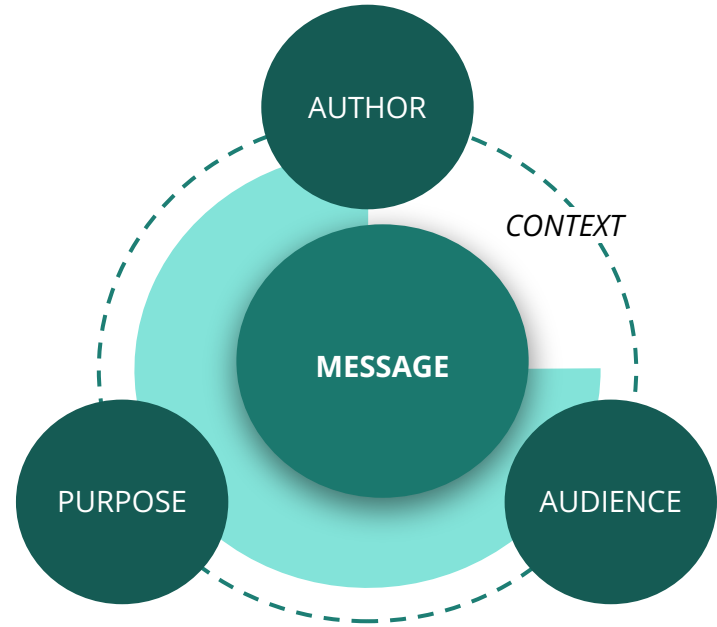
How do I engage in rhetorical analysis?

1. Identify the **rhetorical situation**. Who is speaking, and who is the audience? What is the speaker's purpose, and how does the speaker target their message to the audience?
2. Look for and analyze the **three appeals** (ethos, pathos, logos) in order to understand how the writer establishes his or her argument.
3. Identify specific **rhetorical techniques** the writer uses to accomplish his or her goals.

Rhetorical situation

Every piece of persuasive writing has a rhetorical situation:

- Author: Who is the speaker? What do they know?
- Audience: Who will hear the message? What biases or opinions might the audience have?
- Purpose: What does the writer hope to accomplish?
- Message: What is the author saying? What opinions does he or she offer?
- Context: What are the time, place, and social circumstances of the message?



Three Ways to Appeal to an Audience (Recap)



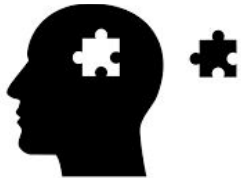
ETHOS:

- Establishing your personal credibility
- Getting your audience to *trust*
- *Achievable by displaying a sincere attitude and balanced perspectives*



PATHOS:

- Inspiring an emotional response
- Getting your audience to *feel*
- *Achievable by vivid description that enables the audience to feel for the author and/or the situation*



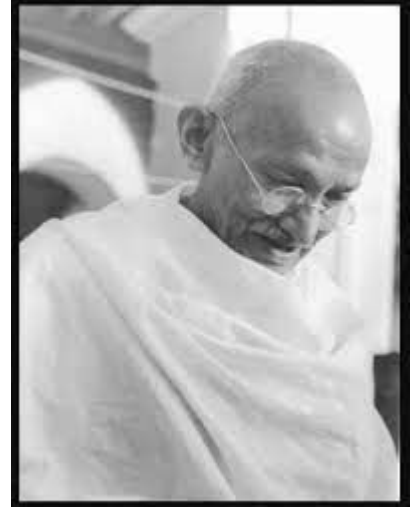
LOGOS:

- Arguing based on reasoning and facts
- Getting your audience to *think*
- *Achievable by providing relevant evidence and solid reasoning*

1. Identify the rhetorical situation

“Here is a mantra, a short one, that I give you. You may imprint it on your hearts and let every breath of yours give expression to it. The mantra is : ‘Do or Die’. We shall either free India or die in the attempt; we shall not live to see the perpetuation of our slavery. Every true Congressman or woman will join the struggle with an inflexible determination not to remain alive to see the country in bondage and slavery. Let that be your pledge.”

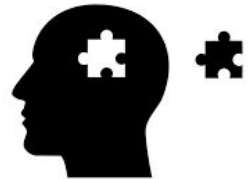
-Mahatma Gandhi, “Quit India” speech excerpt, 1942



2. Look for and analyze the three appeals

“Here is a mantra, a short one, that I give you. You may imprint it on your hearts and let every breath of yours give expression to it. The mantra is : ‘Do or Die’. We shall either free India or die in the attempt; we shall not live to see the perpetuation of our slavery. Every true Congressman or woman will join the struggle with an inflexible determination not to remain alive to see the country in bondage and slavery. Let that be your pledge.”

-Mahatma Gandhi, “Quit India” speech excerpt, 1942



Whole class work

“We should have but one desire today—the desire to die so that India may live—the desire to face a martyr’s death, so that the path to freedom may be paved with the martyr’s blood.

Friends! my comrades in the War of Liberation! Today I demand of you one thing, above all. I demand of you blood. It is blood alone that can avenge the blood that the enemy has spilt. It is blood alone that can pay the price of freedom. Give me blood and I promise you freedom.”

– “Netaji” Subhash Chandra Bose

- ❑ **AUTHOR:** Who is the speaker? What do you know about him?
- ❑ **AUDIENCE:** To whom is he speaking? Who is in his audience? What opinions or perspectives might his audience have?
- ❑ **PURPOSE:** What does the speaker hope to accomplish with his speech?
- ❑ **MESSAGE:** What is the author’s message?
- ❑ **CONTEXT:** What are the time, place, and social circumstances of the message?



Tilak 1917



Nehru 1947

Group activity

Follow the instructions on the assignment sheet to analyze the rhetorical situation and the three appeals.

You will first work with a partner for ten minutes, and then with a group of 4 for ten minutes.

Be prepared to share with the class.



Patel 1947



Bose 1944

PART 1: 10 minutes in a pair

1. With your **partner**, read the speech excerpt below, and then answer the questions that follow on the *rhetorical situation*. You may need to research the speech on the internet to complete your answers. Remember what you have learned in class about finding good sources.
 - **AUTHOR:** Who is the speaker? What do you know about him?
 - **AUDIENCE:** To whom is he speaking? Who is in his audience? What opinions or perspectives might his audience have?
 - **PURPOSE:** What does the speaker hope to accomplish with his speech?
 - **MESSAGE:** What is the author's message?
 - **CONTEXT:** What are the time, place, and social circumstances of the message?

Part 2: 10 minutes in a group of 4

1. Meet with your group and compare answers. Come to a consensus about what you found.
2. Review the definitions for ethos, pathos, and logos.
3. Where do you see examples of ethos, pathos, or logos in the speech? Find at least **a total of two** examples of *any* of the appeals.
4. For each example, cite your evidence, and explain your thinking. Note that there may be multiple examples in one of the three appeals, or none.
5. Be prepared to share with the larger group.

Debrief

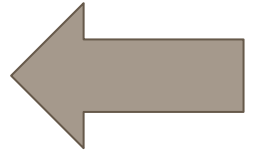
Share your answers for the rhetorical situation.

What examples did you find of ethos, pathos, or logos?

Which of the appeals did you find would be most effective, and why?

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3. Identify specific **rhetorical techniques** the writer uses to accomplish his or her goals.



Rhetorical techniques

Once you have identified and understood the rhetorical situation, you should analyze the **techniques** the writer employs.

For example: we understand that in Gandhi's speech, his purpose was to convince India to pass the "Quit India" resolution, and he mainly appealed to emotion (ethos). But how did he appeal to emotion, and accomplish his purpose? What techniques did he use?

“Here is a mantra, a short one, that I give you. You may imprint it on your hearts and let every breath of yours give expression to it. The mantra is : ‘Do or Die’. We shall either free India or die in the attempt; we shall not live to see the perpetuation of our slavery. Every true Congressman or woman will join the struggle with an inflexible determination not to remain alive to see the country in bondage and slavery. Let that be your pledge.”

Strategy	Example	Analysis and Effect
Command	"Every true Congressman or woman will join the struggle with an inflexible determination not to remain alive to see the country in bondage and slavery."	Gandhi does not ask, but commands his audience. This has an effect of establishing his leadership and authority.
Repetition	"We shall..." "We shall not..."	Repetition draws attention to the comparison being used, and stirs emotion.
Imagery	"You may imprint [the mantra] on your hearts and let every breath of yours give expression to it."	Gandhi visualizes the mantra of the cause as a word on the heart, which stirs emotion in his audience.
Analogy	"...we shall not live to see the perpetuation of our slavery."	He compares British rule to slavery, which heightens the stakes for his audience, and stirs their emotions.
Formal Tone	"We shall..." "you may..." "inflexible determination..." "let that be your pledge."	He uses words that strike a formal tone, and echoes the speeches of prime ministers calling for war, or important leaders. This establishes his authority and brings attention to the seriousness of his purpose.

Some more rhetorical strategies

Let's consult our worksheet.

Rhetorical question; Emotive language;
Statistical figures; Imagery; Analogy;
Formal tone; Hyperbole; Triples;
Command; Flattery; Personal pronouns;
Repetition; Anecdote; Allusion; Oxymoron

How many of these are
familiar/something you've used?

Group activity

Read your assigned speech again, but this time with an eye towards rhetorical strategies.

Complete the rhetorical strategies worksheet with a partner for ten minutes, using the vocabulary guide as a resource.

Discuss with the group of 4 for five minutes, and prepare your answers to be shared.

Debrief

Share your answers for rhetorical strategies.

What did you learn through your analysis? What questions do you have?